
Barriers to Implementing a Just Culture

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CSD 380



What is Just Culture?

DEFINITION

A workplace environment where people feel safe reporting mistakes without fear of unfair punishment

GOALS:

Improve safety, communication, and outcomes

3 CAUSES OF ERRORS

- Human error (unintentional)
- At-risk behavior (risk not recognized)
- Reckless behavior (conscious disregard of risk)



Organizational Barriers

Leadership style strongly affects trust

Blame-focused environments discourage reporting

Lack of transparency about how errors are handled

Weak reporting systems reduce participation

BUSINESS ORGANIZATION





Team and Experience Barriers

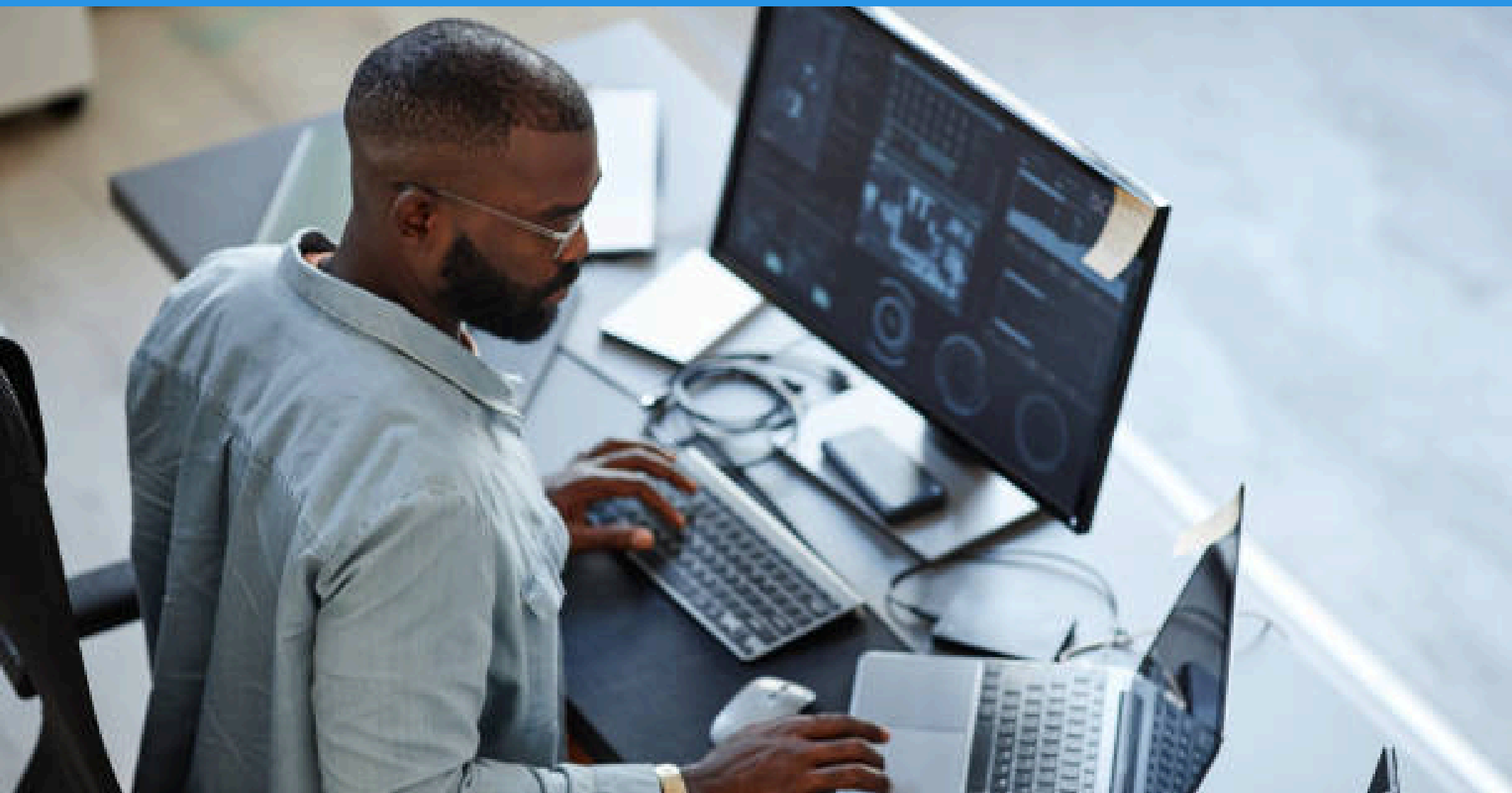
Trust between staff and supervisors is critical

New or less experienced workers fear shame or blame

Lack of training in safety practices lowers confidence

Limited understanding of reporting systems

Personal and Social Barriers



1

People judge mistakes differently based on outcomes

2

Hindsight bias makes errors seem obvious after the fact

3

Fear of peer judgement is strong

4

Trust is fragile and slow to build but quick to lose

Cultural and Linguistic Barriers

Culture cannot simply be designed or mandated

Safety language can emphasize failure rather than learning

Deeply rooted beliefs and assumptions resist change

Misinterpretations can create unrealistic expectations





Legal and Regulatory Barriers

Laws may require punishment for negligence

Fear of lawsuits or criminal charges discourages openness

Regulations can be inconsistent or unclear

External investigators may not understand workplace realities

Technological and System Barriers



1

Complex systems increase risk of unintended failures

2

Technology can amplify consequences of mistakes

3

Poor system design may make errors inevitable

4

Failure to mitigate risks undermines confidence

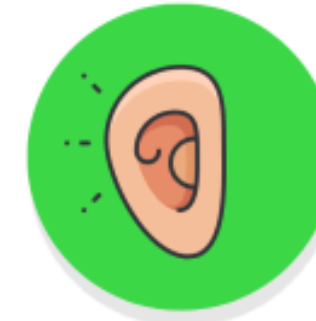
Components of a culture of safety and Just Culture

"Just Culture Infographic.png"
by Valeria Palarski 2020.

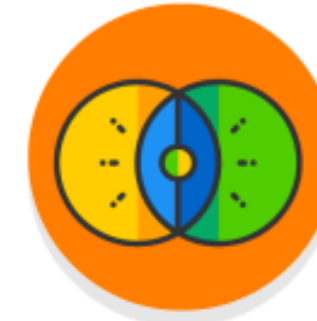
Just Culture



investigate for
safety



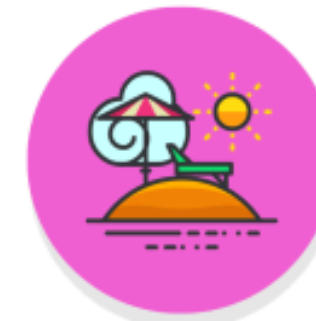
respect others
flatten hierarchies



embrace different
perspectives



champion
innovation



be fair
be consistent



seek improvement
welcome challenge



strive for learning
be kind



trust
encourage curiosity



be transparent
embrace different perspectives

Citations

Ernestmeyer, E., & Christman, K. (2021). 5.4 Culture of Safety. In Nursing fundamentals. essay, XanEdu Publishing Inc.

Shorrock, S. (2025, October 30). Why is it just so difficult? barriers to “just culture” in the real world. Humanistic Systems.

<https://humanisticsystems.com/2023/10/18/why-is-it-just-so-difficult-barriers-to-just-culture-in-the-real-world/>

Van Marum, Sjoerd et al. “The Barriers and Enhancers to Trust in a Just Culture in Hospital Settings: A Systematic Review.” Journal of patient safety vol. 18,7 (2022): e1067-e1075. doi:10.1097/PTS.0000000000001012